

KS3: Early Modern World & Global Encounters (1450–1750)

Ultimate Revision Cheat Sheet

1. Core Chronology

1453 Fall of Constantinople

The Ottoman Empire captured Constantinople, effectively ending the Byzantine Empire and blocking the main European trade route to Asia.

1492 Columbus's First Voyage

Christopher Columbus reached the Americas, initiating widespread European exploration and colonization of the New World.

1494 Treaty of Tordesillas

Spain and Portugal divided the newly discovered lands outside Europe between themselves.

1517 The Protestant Reformation Begins

Martin Luther published his Ninety-five Theses, fracturing Christianity in Europe.

1534 Act of Supremacy

King Henry VIII broke away from the Catholic Church, making himself head of the Church of England.

1569 Mercator World Map

Gerardus Mercator published his famous world map, revolutionising navigation for European sailors.

1577-1580 Drake's Circumnavigation

Sir Francis Drake became the first Englishman to circumnavigate the globe, plundering Spanish ships along the way.

1585 Roanoke Colony Founded

Sir Walter Raleigh organized the first, ultimately unsuccessful, English settlement in North America.

1588 Defeat of the Spanish Armada

England repelled a massive invasion fleet sent by Catholic Spain.

1600 East India Company Founded

Queen Elizabeth I granted a royal charter to the EIC, creating a joint-stock monopoly on trade with Asia.

1607 Jamestown Founded

The first permanent English settlement in the Americas was established in Virginia.

1615 Roe's Embassy to India

Sir Thomas Roe arrived at the Mughal Court to secure trading rights for the East India Company.

1642 English Civil War Begins

Conflict erupted between King Charles I and Parliament over religious and political authority.

1649 Execution of Charles I

King Charles I was executed, and England briefly became a republic led by Oliver Cromwell.

1660 The Restoration

The monarchy was restored under King Charles II after the collapse of the Protectorate.

1694 Bank of England Founded

Created to help fund the government's debt, it triggered a 'Financial Revolution' in Britain.

1720s First Maroon War Begins

Enslaved Africans in Jamaica who had escaped into the mountains fought a prolonged guerrilla war against the British.

1750 Britain on the Eve of Industrialization

London became a booming metropolis marked by extreme wealth, widespread poverty, and global trade connections.

2. Key Individuals

Niccolò Barbaro

VENETIAN DOCTOR & MERCHANT

A Venetian who was present in Constantinople during the Ottoman siege in 1453. He wrote a famous eyewitness diary detailing the fall of the city.

Sultan Mehmed II

OTTOMAN SULTAN

Known as 'The Conqueror', he captured Constantinople at age 21, destroying the Byzantine Empire and transforming the city into the jewel of the Islamic world.

Mansa Musa

EMPEROR OF MALI

The famously wealthy ruler of the Mali Empire. His pilgrimage to Mecca in 1324 demonstrated the vast gold wealth of West Africa to the rest of the world.

Christopher Columbus

EXPLORER

An Italian explorer funded by Spain. His 1492 voyage to find a western sea route to Asia accidentally encountered the Americas, changing world history forever.

Martin Luther

GERMAN MONK & THEOLOGIAN

A German monk who sparked the Protestant Reformation in 1517 by challenging the corruption of the Catholic Church. This triggered centuries of religious conflict.

Sir Francis Drake

ENGLISH PRIVATEER & EXPLORER

A famous English sea captain, privateer, and explorer. He circumnavigated the globe and helped defeat the Spanish Armada in 1588.

Queen Elizabeth I

QUEEN OF ENGLAND

Ruled England during a 'Golden Age'. She oversaw the defeat of the Spanish Armada and the founding of the East India Company, strengthening England's global position.

Pocahontas

POWHATAN DIPLOMAT

A Native American woman who played a crucial role in the survival of the Jamestown colony. She later travelled to England, where she was treated as royalty.

King Charles I

KING OF ENGLAND

His belief in the 'Divine Right of Kings' led to the English Civil War. He was tried and executed by Parliament in 1649.

Oliver Cromwell

LORD PROTECTOR

A Puritan military leader who commanded the Parliamentary army in the Civil War. He ruled England as a republic ('The Protectorate') after Charles I's execution.

Olaudah Equiano

ABOLITIONIST & WRITER

An enslaved African who bought his own freedom and wrote a bestselling autobiography exposing the horrors of the Transatlantic Slave Trade.

Nanny of the Maroons

MAROON LEADER & NATIONAL HERO

An iconic Jamaican leader of the Windward Maroons. Born in West Africa, she escaped slavery in Jamaica and led a highly successful guerrilla war against the British colonial forces.

Admiral Zheng He

MING DYNASTY EXPLORER

undefined

John Hawkins

ENGLISH PRIVATEER & SLAVE
TRADER

undefined

King Philip II

KING OF SPAIN

undefined

Henry VIII

KING OF ENGLAND

undefined

Pope Alexander VI

HEAD OF THE CATHOLIC
CHURCH

undefined

Sir Walter Raleigh

ENGLISH EXPLORER &
COURTIER

undefined

Mary, Queen of Scots

QUEEN OF SCOTLAND

undefined

Don Francisco de Zárte

SPANISH CAPTAIN

undefined

King James I

KING OF ENGLAND AND
SCOTLAND

undefined

John Rolfe

ENGLISH PLANTER

undefined

Chief Powhatan

INDIGENOUS LEADER

undefined

Emperor Jahangir

MUGHAL EMPEROR

undefined

Sir Thomas Roe

ENGLISH DIPLOMAT

undefined

John Bradshaw

JUDGE

undefined

Martin Noell

LONDON MERCHANT

undefined

Charles II

KING OF ENGLAND

undefined

Gerrard Winstanley

RADICAL LEADER (THE
DIGGERS)

undefined

William Wilberforce

ENGLISH ABOLITIONIST

undefined

Thomas Clarkson

ABOLITIONIST CAMPAIGNER

undefined

Kritovoulos of Imbros

GREEK SCHOLAR &
HISTORIAN

A Greek scholar who lived through the fall of the Byzantine Empire. Instead of resisting, he entered the service of Sultan Mehmed II.

Prof. Peter Frankopan

PROFESSOR OF GLOBAL
HISTORY, OXFORD

He is famous for challenging Eurocentric history, arguing that for thousands of years the true centre of global wealth and power lay in Asia.

Dr. Geoffrey Parker

LEADING EXPERT ON THE SPANISH EMPIRE

His revisionist work on the Spanish Armada argues that the English victory was due to Spanish logistical failures and superior English ship design.

Sir John Seeley

VICTORIAN HISTORIAN

A 19th-century historian writing at the height of the British Empire. He famously argued that the British Empire was acquired 'in a fit of absence of mind'.

Prof. Shashi Tharoor

INDIAN POLITICIAN & HISTORIAN

A former UN Under-Secretary-General. He aggressively dismantles the myth of a 'benevolent' British Empire.

Prof. Christopher Hill

MARXIST HISTORIAN

One of the most famous Marxist historians of the 20th century, based at Oxford. He argued the English Civil War was a revolutionary class struggle.

Prof. Eric Williams

HISTORIAN & PRIME MINISTER

A brilliant historian who later became the first Prime Minister of Trinidad and Tobago.

Reginald Coupland

IMPERIAL HISTORIAN

An Oxford historian writing in the 1930s. He promoted the 'Traditional Imperial View' of abolition.

Prof. Roy Porter

MEDICAL & SOCIAL HISTORIAN

A highly prolific historian at the Wellcome Institute. He argued that by the 18th century, Britain was a deeply modern, secular, consumer-driven society.

Prof. J.C.D. Clark

REVISIONIST HISTORIAN

A prominent revisionist historian who fiercely challenged Porter's view.

Harriet Tubman

ABOLITIONIST & ACTIVIST

undefined

Toussaint Louverture

HAITIAN REVOLUTIONARY LEADER

undefined

Thomas Thistlewood

JAMAICAN OVERSEER

undefined

3. Master Glossary

Term	Definition
Armada	A fleet of warships, particularly the Spanish fleet that sailed against England under the command of [Key Individual: King Philip II] in 1588.
Charter	A written grant by a country's sovereign or legislative power, by which a company is created and its rights and privileges defined.

Term	Definition
Commonwealth	The republic that ruled England from 1649 to 1660 following the execution of Charles I.
Covert Resistance	Hidden or secretive acts of rebellion, such as working slowly or breaking tools.
Divine Right of Kings	The belief that a monarch's authority comes directly from God, making them unaccountable to earthly authorities like Parliament.
Factory	In the 17th century, a fortified trading post or warehouse established by a merchant company in a foreign country.
Indulgences	In the Catholic Church, a grant by the Pope of remission of the temporal punishment in purgatory still due for sins after absolution.
Joint-Stock Company	A company whose stock is owned jointly by the shareholders, spreading the financial risk of overseas ventures.
Maroons	Communities of formerly enslaved Africans who escaped and established free settlements in mountainous or remote areas.
Mercantile	Relating to trade or commerce; commercial.
Middle Passage	The brutal forced voyage of enslaved Africans across the Atlantic Ocean.
Modernity	In history, the transition away from traditional, agricultural, feudal societies towards commercial, secular, and industrialized ones.
Monopoly	The exclusive possession or control of the supply or trade in a commodity or service.
National Debt	Money borrowed by a government (often via a central bank like the Bank of England) to fund state activities like war.
Navigation Acts	Laws passed in 1651 requiring all trade between England and its colonies to be carried in English ships, boosting mercantile wealth.
New Model Army	A revolutionary, disciplined, and religiously motivated professional army formed by Parliament during the Civil War.
Obeah	A system of spiritual and healing practices developed by enslaved people in the Caribbean, often involving botanical knowledge.
Plantation	A large agricultural estate where enslaved people were forced to grow cash crops like sugar and tobacco.

Term	Definition
Privateer	An armed ship owned by private individuals holding a government commission (Letter of Marque) and authorized for use in war, especially in the capture of enemy merchant shipping.
Reformation	A 16th-century religious movement in Europe that resulted in the creation of Protestant churches and a split from the Catholic Church.
Rotten Borough	A tiny parliamentary constituency with very few voters, easily bought or controlled by a wealthy aristocrat.
Subjugation	The action of bringing someone or something under domination or control.
Synoptic	Taking a comprehensive mental view of a wide series of events across a long period of time.
The Bloody Code	The harsh 18th-century English legal system which mandated the death penalty for over 200 minor crimes.
Triangular Trade	The three-legged transatlantic trade network connecting Europe, Africa, and the Americas.

4. Core Concepts & Big Questions

- Why would a mapmaker in Europe in 1375 depict an African king with such prominent symbols of wealth?
- Does this map suggest the English victory was due to superior skill, or lucky geography and weather?
- How can the exact same historical figure be remembered as both a national hero and a criminal pirate?
- What does the presence of multiple international flags, rather than a single European military fort, suggest about who held the real power in Canton?
- Does this portrait tell us more about [Key Individual: Pocahontas]'s actual identity, or about what the English wanted to see?
- Why was it so important for the monarch to create a single, unified visual identity for the newly formed nation?
- How did the execution of Charles I permanently change the balance of power between the Monarchy and Parliament?
- Why was a cold, technical diagram more effective at changing public opinion than an emotional painting might have been?
- How does a map like this hide the human suffering and enslaved labor required to make those estates profitable?
- What were the major risks of living in such densely packed, unregulated urban environments?
- Is this image a reliable reflection of daily life in 1751, or an exaggerated moral panic designed to shock the viewer?